

MYRTALES

The nine families in the Myrtales are most common in warmer regions. The 5,800 species in the Myrtaceae or myrtle family provide essential oils, spices, and fruits such as guava. They include over 700 species of eucalypts from Australia and New Guinea. The Lythraceae or loosestrife family consists mainly of tropical trees and shrubs, producing fruits such as pomegranate and various dyes, and the Melastomataceae is a pan-tropical family of around 4,500 trees, shrubs, and climbers.



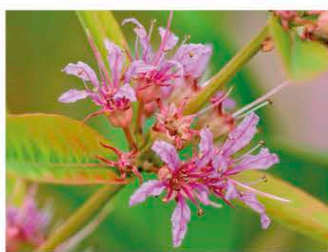
CRAPE MYRTLE
Lagerstroemia indica
F: Lythraceae

Blooming for up to 120 days, this tree is native to China, Korea, and Japan. Its bark is smooth, mottled, pinkish-grey, and is shed each year.



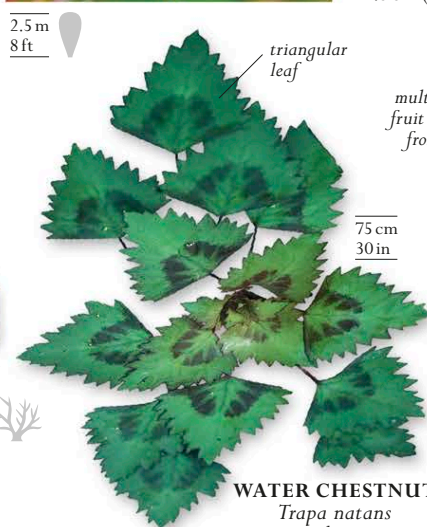
HENNA
Lawsonia inermis
F: Lythraceae

Native to N. Africa and the Middle East, henna's leaves make a reddish-brown dye and its fragrant flowers yield essential oils.



SWAMP LOOSESTRIFE
Decodon verticillatus
F: Lythraceae

Native to N.E. America, this shrub grows in swamps. It has arching stems with leaves in whorls of three, and red or purple flowers up to 2.5 cm (1 in) across.



WATER CHESTNUT
Trapa natans
F: Lythraceae

This floating plant is from Europe and Asia. It has an edible starchy seed in a nut with four horn-like barbed spines.



POMEGRANATE
Punica granatum
F: Lythraceae

This spiny, shrubby tree, from S.W. Asia, is widely cultivated in the Mediterranean for its pulpy fruits, containing numerous seeds.

PURPLE LOOSESTRIFE
Lythrum salicaria
F: Lythraceae

Numerous purple-red, square stems grow from the woody, creeping rootstock of this perennial. Native to Europe, Asia, S.E. Australia, and N.W. Africa, it can be invasive.



CIGAR FLOWER
Cuphea ignea
F: Lythraceae

A densely branched, perennial shrub, cigar flower is a garden and house ornamental, native to Mexico. Its fruits are paper-like capsules.



RANGOON CREEPER
Combretum indicum
F: Combretaceae

This climber from tropical Asia has clusters of tubular red flowers. Its ellipsoidal fruits, each with five wings, taste of almonds.



INDIAN ALMOND
Terminalia catappa
F: Combretaceae

Found on coasts of the Indo-Pacific oceans, this tree has horizontal branches. Its corky fruit, dispersed by water, contains an edible, almond-tasting nut.



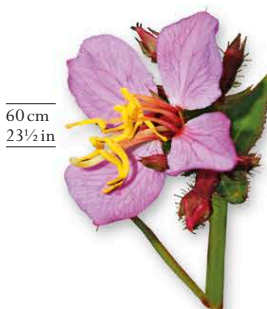
ROSE GRAPE
Medinilla magnifica
F: Melastomataceae

This ornamental from the Philippines is an epiphyte, growing on trees. Its leaves have the longitudinal veins characteristic of the melastomes.



BRAZILIAN SPIDER FLOWER
Tibouchina urvilleana
F: Melastomataceae

In warm regions this Brazilian ornamental blooms for most of the year. Its velvety leaves have red edges and three to five obvious longitudinal veins.



VIRGINIA MEADOW BEAUTY
Rhexia virginica
F: Melastomataceae

This hairy, perennial herb from E. USA and Canada grows on wetlands. It has square stems and stalkless leaves with toothed margins.